

STARTUPS



The wait is almost over: The 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list drops August 27



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After reviewing thousands of groundbreaking applications from around the globe, TechCrunch is just days away from announcing the 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 — our handpicked cohort of the most promising early-stage startups set to take the stage at [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) this October 27-29.

The 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list will go live, right here, on Wednesday, August 27, at 9:00 a.m. PT.

Whether you applied, referred a standout founder, or just want to see who made the cut, this is the moment you've been waiting for. Your name. Your rival. Your next investment. They might all be on this list.

This October marks 20 years that [TechCrunch Disrupt](#) has been shaping the startup world — and we're pulling out all the stops.

For two decades, the biggest names in tech, venture capital, and startups have taken our stage to share their visions and make history. Game-changers like Dropbox, Cloudflare, Fitbit, and Discord got their start in [Startup Battlefield](#) — and this is where the next generation of breakout companies will be born.

IMAGE CREDITS: [FLICKR](#)

Want to see these rising stars pitch live? Hear from top-tier founders and investors? Network with the people shaping the future of tech? [Grab your ticket to Disrupt 2025](#), happening October 27-29 in San Francisco.

Last year's winner, [Salva Health](#), topped a competitive field of startups with its development of a portable device to detect breast cancer early, especially in rural populations that lack access to mammograms and other diagnostic tools. You can relive their victory below, [listen to our Equity podcast interview with CEO Valentina Agudelo](#), or [get a detailed rundown of their journey here](#).



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Announcing the winner of Startup Battlefield 200 | TechCr...

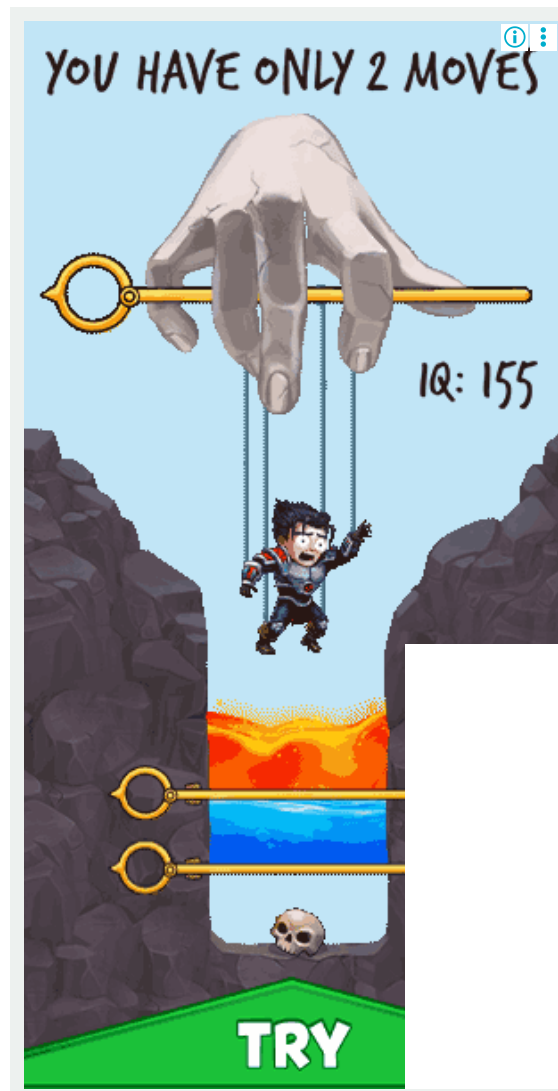


Salva was far from alone. Out of the cohort of 200 trailblazing startups, TechCrunch editorial selected the [2024 Top 20 finalists](#) who wowed the crowd with their disruptive innovations, live demos, and perfected pitches. Runner-up [geCKo Materials](#) [turned heads with its compelling story](#) about how years of research led to a breakthrough innovation in adhesive materials that is disrupting the Velcro industry one impossibly sticky situation at a time.

This year's Startup Battlefield 200 Top 20 finalists will be revealed on Day 1 of Disrupt 2025 (Monday, October 27). You don't want to miss the chance to see these founders battle it out live onstage for the \$100,000 prize and Disrupt Cup. Your incumbent will be there. Your competitors have registered. Don't get left behind — [get your tickets to Disrupt 2025](#).

Mark your calendars and set your alarms — the 2025 Startup Battlefield 200 list drops right here on Wednesday, August 27, at 9:00 a.m. PT. Be the first to see which exceptional startups made the cut.

Startup Battlefield is proudly presented by Google Cloud, our premier sponsor.



STARTUP BATTLEFIELD 200

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Isabelle Johannessen

Startup Battlefield Program Manager

Isabelle leads Startup Battlefield, TechCrunch's iconic launchpad and competition for the world's most promising early-stage startups....

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Why Paradigm built a spreadsheet with an AI agent in every cell

Rebecca Szkutak — 8:00 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Monaco has been building AI agents since before the term “AI agents” was even a thing. After building numerous chatbots, he started looking for other types of interfaces that made sense for AI agents and landed on spreadsheets.

“I had this personal pattern, and I noticed that a lot of other people had this pattern, of putting very important CRM data in spreadsheets just because it was the most flexible thing,”

IMAGE CREDITS: PARADIGM

Monaco told TechCrunch. “But it was actually a pain to maintain. There’s so much manual work involved. So [I] just went down this rabbit hole of building a product for myself and wanted to reimagine what a spreadsheet could look like with the full power of LLMs.”

The result was [Paradigm](#), an AI-powered spreadsheet equipped with more than 5,000 AI agents. Users can assign different prompts to individual columns and cells, and individual AI agents will crawl the internet to find and fill out the needed information.

Paradigm works with AI models from Anthropic, OpenAI, and Google’s Gemini, Monaco said, and supports model switching.

“We want to support every single model because we want our users to be able to have the highest reasoning outputs when they need it, but also the cheapest outputs,” Monaco said. “It’s just a constant cycle of evaluating different models, working closely with model providers to make sure our limits are high enough, and then giving some of that power to our users.”

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The company launched a small closed beta preview in late 2024 and has been iterating on the product using customer feedback. Paradigm attracts users ranging from consultants to sales professionals and finance folks and operates on a subscription model with tiers based on usage. Paradigm counts the consulting firm EY, AI chip startup Etched, and AI coding company Cognition as early customers.

Paradigm is now releasing its product to the public and announcing that it raised a \$5 million seed round led by General Catalyst. The company has raised \$7 million to date. Monaco said the funding will go toward executing on the company’s “extremely aggressive product roadmap.”



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“The interesting thing that happened when we fundraised is some people we pitched just kept on using and paying for the product,” Monaco said. “I think that was a cool part of it. We found a lot of value from it internally and our investors, not even just our investors — other investors that we talked to — are still using it.”

Paradigm isn’t the only company looking to give spreadsheets an AI upgrade. [Quadratic](#), which has raised more than \$6 million in venture funding, is a 3-year-old startup with a similar goal. Legacy companies like Google and Microsoft are also adding AI tools to their spreadsheet applications.

Monaco said that she doesn’t really consider the competition because Paradigm doesn’t think of itself as an AI-powered spreadsheet. She said she thinks of it as a new AI-powered

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workflow that happens to be in the familiar form of a spreadsheet but won't necessarily stay that way forever.

“What I’m seeing in the most popular AI products now is this fine balance between present and future,” Monaco said. “How do you build something that is really powerful and generates a lot of value now but also sets you up really well for the future? That’s the question that I asked myself a year ago when I was starting the company.”

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Rebecca Szkutak

Senior Reporter, Venture | [in](#)

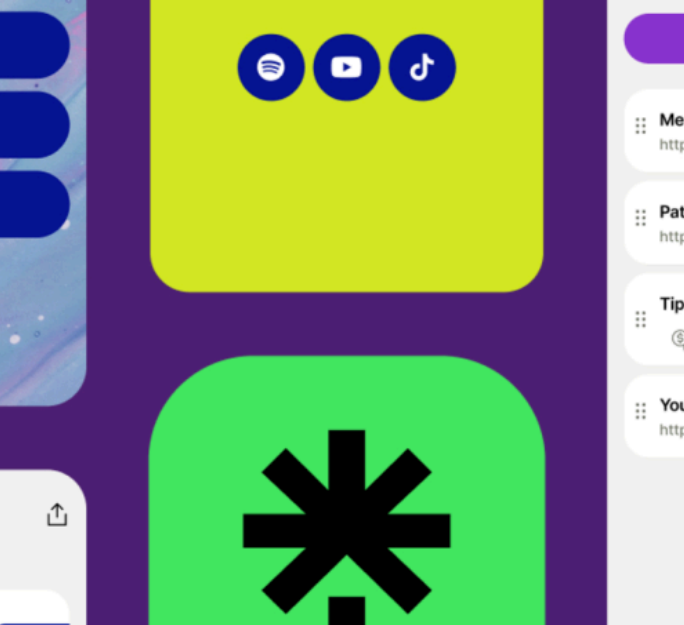
Becca is a senior writer at TechCrunch that covers venture capital trends and startups. She previously covered the same beat for Forbes and the...

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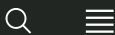
Linktree goes dark in India — and the company isn't sure why

Jagmeet Singh — 7:46 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

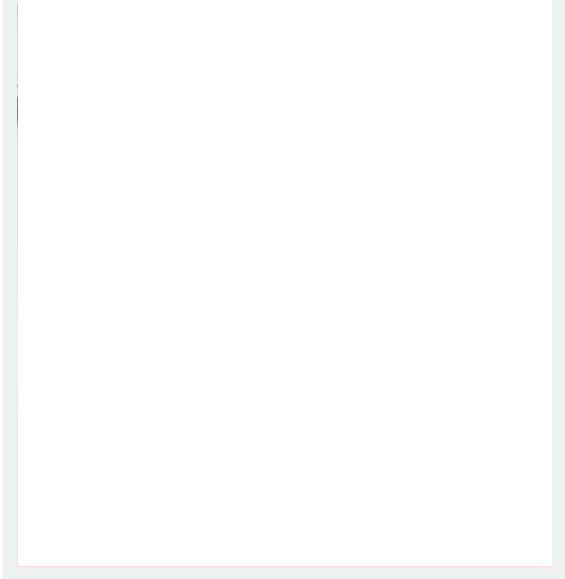


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Founded in 2016, Linktree [became a unicorn in 2022](#) and [surpassed 50 million users](#) in 2024. India has been the platform's fifth-largest market by traffic, accounting for 3.5% of its global visits — or about 7.3 million in July, per Similarweb data shared with TechCrunch.



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Linktree's monthly visits in India

(in millions)

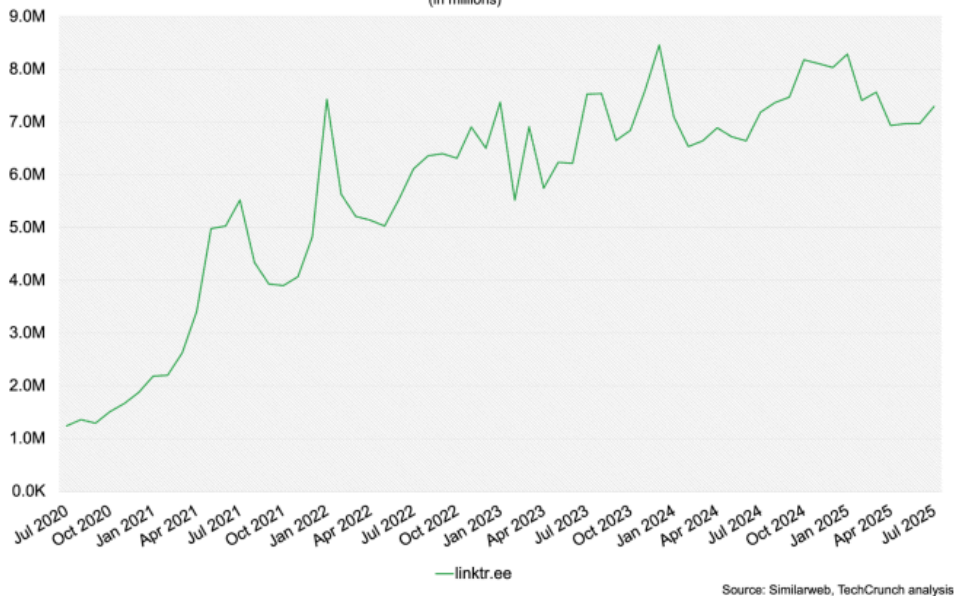


IMAGE CREDITS: JAGMEET SINGH / TECHCRUNCH

Linktree co-founder and CEO Alex Zaccaria told TechCrunch that the startup was looking into the situation. However, the executive did not confirm whether the startup received a communication from Indian authorities on its blockage.

The startup later [posted](#) on X that it was aware of the service outage in India and was “investigating” the issue.

As [reported](#) by the Indian daily The Hindu, the outage is not limited to a specific internet service provider and appears to affect all major networks.

The U.S. remains Linktree’s top market, with 48.5 million visits, followed by Indonesia (32.3 million), Brazil (30.8 million), and the U.K. (9.4 million), Similarweb data shows.

India’s IT and telecom ministries did not respond to emails sent over the weekend.

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Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for TechCrunch. He previously...

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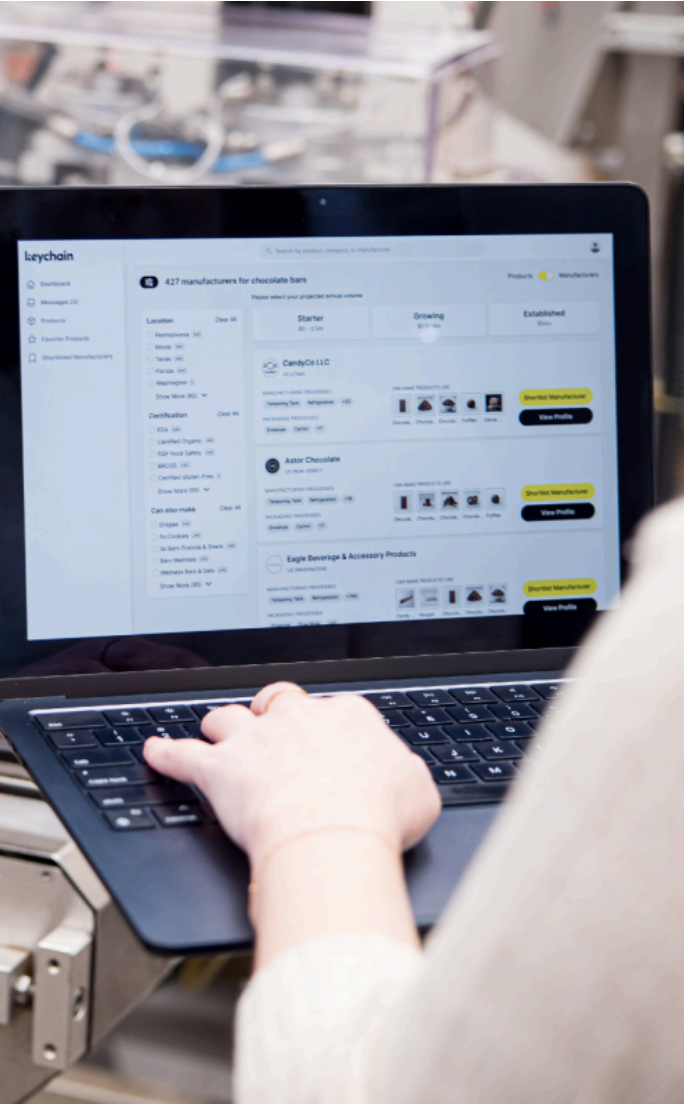


IMAGE CREDITS: KEYCHAIN

ENTERPRISE

CPG startup Keychain snags \$30M to build in India, grow in the U.S.

Jagmeet Singh — 7:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

Keychain, a U.S. startup that helps consumer brands find manufacturing partners, has raised \$30 million in fresh funding as it looks to scale its India-based development team to drive growth in North America.

While headquartered in New York, Keychain operates as a distributed company with its core engineering and product

development centered in India. The startup is doubling down on this model with the new funding, aiming to grow its engineering, product design, and analytics teams in Gurugram from 35 to 70 in the coming months, and to around 100 within a year. This India-based team already represents half of Keychain’s 70-person global headcount, with about 20 employees in New York and the remainder in Austin, handling partnerships, go-to-market, and sales.

The strategy is deliberate. Despite only serving Western markets, Keychain has built its primary development operations in in Gurugram — which is the country’s second-largest tech hub after Bengaluru — to develop its consumer packaged goods (CPG) platform for clients in North America. The software platform already helps eight of the top 10 retailers, including 7-Eleven and Whole Foods, and seven of the top CPG brands, such as General Mills, connect with potentially suitable manufacturers, according to the startup. So why India?

“It’s the talent, depth, availability, and the speed with which you can access talent of that depth and availability [in India],” said Oisin Hanrahan, co-founder and CEO of Keychain, in an interview.

Hanrahan co-founded Keychain in 2023 with Umang Dua — his co-founder at Handy, a home services software startup later acquired by Angi — and Jordan Weitz. Dua, who is originally from New Delhi, has been a “natural advantage” in building Keychain’s core teams in Gurugram, Hanrahan said.



KEYCHAIN CO-FOUNDERS JORDAN WEITZ, OISIN HANRAHAN, AND UMANG DUA
(LEFT TO RIGHT)

IMAGE CREDITS:KEYCHAIN



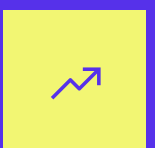
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Both Hanrahan and Dua spent time structuring Keychain's teams across India and the U.S., ultimately choosing India as the company's engineering hub. The decision was shaped by their experience at Handy and Angi, where they found it challenging to build a "sustainable, enduring" engineering team in the U.S.

"We've thought about engineering as: how do we build a core, sustainable engineering organization that can get to scale reasonably quickly, that has endurance, that's got deep talent pools, and AI exposure that can take on real, important challenges, that's commercially minded? And we looked at where we had those teams before, when we were at Handy and Angi, and obviously, India is just an amazing location and really checks a lot of those boxes," Hanrahan told TechCrunch.

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Several U.S. startups, [especially those developing SaaS solutions](#), base their engineering and product teams in cities like Bengaluru, Gurugram, and Noida. In recent months, the country has also seen a [wave of multinational companies establishing offshore hubs](#), often referred to as global capability centers. But unlike most of these firms — which also target Indian consumers even as many say [India is harder to sell into](#) — Keychain stands apart. It more closely resembles companies like the UK's [Deliveroo](#) and Southeast Asia's [Gojek](#) and [Grab](#) — all of which tap into India's tech talent for product development and R&D without having a market presence in the country.

"India's position as a global technology hub has made it a compelling destination for product development, even for startups that have no direct business in the country," said Neha

Singh, co-founder of the Bengaluru-based private market intelligence platform Tracxn, in an interview with TechCrunch.

India's time zone also allows teams to work beyond U.S. hours, enabling near-continuous development cycles, Singh added.

KeychainOS as the next big thing coming from Indian talent

Keychain plans to use its India team not only to improve its current platform — launched in February 2024 and used by over 20,000 brands and retailers to find manufacturing partners — but also to build new AI-powered software that helps manufacturers manage their product cycles more efficiently and with better oversight.

Called KeychainOS, the software will have four modules, with the first one already available. This module helps manufacturers comply with their food safety requirements, using AI to take quantitative data and convert it into a qualitative report that can be shared with auditors. The software can also pull data using natural language when an auditor requests a specific insight, Hanrahan told TechCrunch.

The other three modules of the software will focus on purchasing and procurement, inventory, and production planning, the executive noted.

The OS offering will compete with traditional ERP systems like Oracle, QAD, and Plex, which require add-ons like TraceGains and Redzone to be usable for manufacturers, the startup said.

In addition to its KeychainOS for manufacturers, Keychain has embedded AI into its search and discovery layer to help retailers quickly find relevant third-party manufacturers for their products.

KEYCHAIN'S SEARCH AND DISCOVERY LAYER WITH AN AI INTEGRATION

IMAGE CREDITS:KEYCHAIN

Keychain already helps brands and retailers find third-party manufacturers in food, beverage, supplements, health, and beauty categories and is looking to expand its platform to pet and household products later this year.

Currently, the startup serves businesses in the U.S. and Canada and is [aiming to enter Europe](#) later this year.

While the startup offers its software free to brands and retailers, manufacturers pay to access the platform and get discovered. KeychainOS provides them with another reason to engage.

Keychain already has over 30,000 manufacturers on its platform, with “hundreds and hundreds” paying to use it. These customers pay anywhere from \$10,000 to over \$100,000, Hanrahan said, adding that the startup earns around \$20,000 per manufacturer annually on average.

Keychain's Series B round was led by Wellington Management and existing investor BoxGroup, alongside other existing investors. With this funding, the startup has raised \$68 million in total. Of that, Hanrahan told TechCrunch that the startup still has over \$50 million in the bank.

The startup had a post-money valuation of \$260 million in its last round of \$15 million in November 2024. Hanrahan did not disclose the current valuation but said it was a “good step up.”

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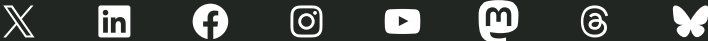
Jagmeet Singh

Reporter |

Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for TechCrunch. He previously...

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